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展望中国人文地理学的发展

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提 要 中国自改革开放以来，人文地理学得到了复兴，在理论、方法和研究内容方面都有了新的发展，其中尤以经济地理学、城市地理学和旅游地理学的进展较快，原先被视为禁区的政治地理学、文化地理学和社会地理学，也开始出现了一批可喜的成果。目前在中国经济体制转轨的新形势下，中国人文地理学正处于一个重要的转折时期，即面临着严重的挑战，又出现了前所未有的发展机遇。

在迈入21世纪时，作者建议中国人文地理学着重研究以下各课题：

（1）为充实中国人文地理学的基础理论，研究人地关系地域系统；

（2）为配合（中国21世纪议程）的实施，研究全国和各地区社会经济的持续发展；

（3）以土地利用为中心来研究全球变化和人类活动的关系；

（4）从节约利用和保护资源出发，研究地区自然资源系统；

（5）为发扬中国地理学的传统，更认真地为农业服务，研究促进农业和农村的持续发展问题；

（6）从理论和方法上提高区域地理研究的水平、并配合国家任务，开展区域综合发展的研究，包括国家和各省经济建设的重点区、海域、生态脆弱区等。

关键词 中国人文地理学 人地关系 持续发展、全球变化 资源系统 农业现代化 区域综合发展

近半个世纪以来，中国人文地理学的发展并非一帆风顺。50年代学习前苏联的经验，对人文地理学贴上了唯心主义伪科学的标签，不少人文地理学术著作遭到政治性的批判。直到“文化大革命”后的1978年，中国政府拨乱反正，把国家工作重点转向现代化建设，为科研工作带来了春天。1979年，中国地理学会在广州召开了代表大会，根据国家建设的客观需求和使中国地理学科得到健康而平衡的发展，号召复兴人文地理学。从此冲破了一些过去由于政治原因而形成的“禁区”，人文地理学的很多薄弱学科得到了加强，一些空白领域开始得到填充，更多的中青年地理工作者投入到人文地理学的研究。

在改革开放以来的将近20年过程中，中国人文地理学已取得了可喜的发展。由于坚持为生产建设服务的方针，研究内容比过去丰富而多样化了，广泛参加了国土开发、整治与规划工作。农业区划和农村综合发展研究、城市发展规划、城市体系和城市土地评价、土地和旅游资源的合理利用与开发规划、环境的综合治理和合理容量、生产力优化布局和地区综合发展，以及人地关系地域系统等基础理论问题的研究。与此同时并编制出版了国家农业地图集和经济地图集，以及全国性的人口地图集和土地利用地图集。此外还出版了《人文地理学丛书》和多种分支学科的专著，出现了建国以来空前繁荣的局面。

由于客观存在的问题和提出的研究任务大都具有综合性，这就要求地理学的发展在专业分化的同时，要更多注意和加强高度的综合，为了较好地解决问题，需要多学科的协同研究。为此，越来越多的自然地理工作者参予了上述各项任务的研究，从而开始扭转了长期以来自然地理与人文地理工作者互不关心、分道扬镳的局面。同时，地理工作者不再划地为牢，固守所谓地理学的传统领域，而是主动和

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其他有关的自然、社会、技术科学工作者联系，对一些有关领域进行交叉研究，从而促进了区域科学、环境科学、资源科学、国土经济学、城市科学、人类生态学等边缘学科和交叉学科的发展。其中特别如经济地理学和区域科学已经进入了相互交融，你中有我、我中有你的境界，区域科学的学科带头人艾萨特（W. Isard）称这二者为“孪生学科”。

人文地理研究对象已由单要素向多要素、由部门向综合发展，由静态描述向动态分析发展，由定向性向精确度量发展。为此注意到调研方法的革新和工效的提高，开始建立各项信息传输系统和各种应用性工作的工作规范，发展方法论。想方设法“硬化”人文地理这门软科学，使人文地理各项调研任务最后提出的各种促进经济效益、社会效益和环境效益的建议和措施，要十分具体并便于操作，如此则可受到各有关生产业务部门的欢迎。方法的革新有助于理论和学术思想的更新，并使中国人文地理工作者和国际同行们具有共同的思路、方法和语言，便于走向国际合作的前沿。事实上、中国老、中、青人文地理工作者已加强了国际学术交流的参与，踊跃走上国际学术论坛，使中国的人文地理研究和国际接轨。

中国的地理环境复杂，文化历史悠久，人口总量大而民族众多，就这些基本国情而论，发展人文地理研究，其内容将比世界任何一国都丰富。利用这个地理背景的特点和优势，适应社会、经济、政治、文化的发展趋势和改革开放的需要，研究中国在现代化建设过程中出现的一系具有鲜明的地域性和综合性相结合的重大问题，并把解决这些问题作为主攻方向这就有可能建立具有中国特色的人文地理学。

人文地理研究不能脱离国情背景，中国目前工业化尚未根本实现，人口压力大，城市化水平低，城乡二元结构影响各个方面，为数日益增长的农业剩余劳动力有待转业安置，自然地理环境和文化、经济、技术水平在各地区各民族之间也极不平衡，为此生产建设既要强调因地制宜，又要重视地区公平，以保证国家的政治安定和民族团结。过去由于未能全面考虑地区公平和效益问题，出现多次失衡。人文地理学中的经济地理学直接受到经济转轨的影响，自70年代末开始的市场取向的体制改革后，中国经济地理研究由原先局限于生产而扩展到联系流通交换与消费，把生产力布局扩大为产业布局，乃至经济布局。而研究经济布局的着眼点，除自然资源和自然条件外，还需要联系社会、人文因素，同时在方法上引入建立模型、模拟仿真、科学预测、机制分析等方法手段，加强了研究深度。为适应市场经济的新形势下开展工作的需要，经济地理工作者首先要更新观念，同时要改变专业知识结构，要补充有关市场经济体制、制度、运行机制及行为为主体方面的知识，既要懂得市场调节的作用，还要懂得宏观调控的必要，总之，工作的难度增加了。

应该说当前中国人文地理学正处于一个重要的转折时期，既面临着严重挑战的新局面，又出现了前所未有的发展机遇。当前迈入21世纪之际，考虑中国人文地理学今后的发展方向，既要了解国际上地理学的重大研究课题和主要发展趋向，尽可能多方位和国际接轨，在一些全球性的研究中占有一定的份额，而更重要的是要根据中国社会经济发展的需要，来确定中国人文地理学近期的发展战略，主要要进行下列6方面的研究：

1 人地关系地域系统

这是地理研究的核心，也是地理学基础理论的组成部分。地理学是认识自然世界的自然科学和认识人文世界的人文科学之间的联系题目（Linking subject），二者的联结点便是人地关系。当然研究人地关系这个大问题的学科不限于地理一门，哲学、社会科学和生物科学也研究，但以地域空间为单元来研究人地关系只有地理学一家。现代地理学研究地球表层人类社会系统和地理环境系统在同一地域内组合成的巨系统，它的组成要素复杂而多样，它的空间结构跨度大并具有多层次性和明显的地域差异性，再加上人类活动的时序性也很突出，因此综合研究不同社会发展阶段人地关系地域系统的动态变化规律及其差异特征，便成为地理学有别于其他科学的最主要特征。

研究的目标是协调在不同类型地域内人类活动和地理环境的关系，以求得在一定地域范围内二者的动态平衡，实现持续发展。可以运用综合集成的方法，选用定量和定性两方面的系列指标，来模拟人地双方的相互作用和引发的变化及其后果，设法优化人地关系地域系统的结构，并进行经济效益、社会

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效益和环境效益的评价。人地关系地域系统的协调、互补，正是地理学的重要应用研究和发展其基础理论的立足点。

2　**地区社会经济持续发展**

80年代初，不同专业的科学家集会讨论什么是最紧迫的全球性问题，结论是协调人类活动和地理环境的关系。1987年联合国世界环境与发展委员会（WCED）发表了“我们的共同未来”报告，首先提出人类社会发展要遵循公平性（fairness）持续性（sustainability）和共同性（common）三个原则，强调“满足当代人的需求，而又不损害其子孙后代满足其需求能力的发展”概括了可持续发展的涵义。1992年联合国在Rio召开世界环境与发展会议，提出“21世纪议程”，进一步说明实施持续发展的提纲。中国政府积极响应，于1995年制定了“中国21世纪议程”。

可持续发展现在已成为一个热门话题，但在国际上地理、生态、社会经济等不同专业的科学家和技术专家，对此有不同的倾向。比较全面的理解应该是保持人类自身的再生产、自然再生产和经济再生产这三大基本生产的平衡，只有在人口增长不超过资源和环境的承载能力的前提下，社会和经济才能保持持续发展。“21世纪议程”的内容涉及地理学领域的方面很多，其中心任务是协调人口、资源、环境的关系，谋求各地区、各国乃至全世界社会经济的持续发展。关键是如何在谋求二字上做文章，中国的人文地理学家们以P—R—E—D模式概括而画龙点睛地说明了这一主旨。以“21世纪议程”为导向，探讨人地关系的调控规律，制定全国和不同类型地区社会，经济持续发展的模式，为国家宏观决策提供科学依据，应是中国人文地理研究近期的主攻方向。在此基础上可以建立预测地理学和发展地理学这类新的分支学科。

3　**人类活动与全球变化**

全球变化研究最初是80年代初由世界气象组织（WMO）发起进行全球气候变化研究。1986年由国际科联（ICSU）主席肯特鲁（J. Kendrew）提出国际地圈生物圈计划（IGBP），开展了世界范围规模最大的地学和生物学合作研究活动，目标是把全地球作为一个整体，从维护出发研究它的变化规律。把人类活动和全球变化的关系联结在一起进行研究则是1987年由国际高级研究组织联盟（IFIAS）发起的“人类对全球变化的反应（Human Response to Global Change）”，次年由联合国大学（东京）提出研究“全球变化的人文度量（Human Dimension of Global Chang）”，内容涉及：资源利用、土地利用、能源利用、工业增长、环境变化评价和环境安全持续发展以及各国人文组织与制度对全球变化的影响等。目前有关人类活动与全球变化的研究由国际社会科学委员会（ISSC）牵头，但组织得很不得力，工作进展不大。考虑到全球变化和土地利用的关系比较最为明显并便于度量，中国对这方面研究可以此为突破口，并结合脆弱地带（Critical Zone）进行典型调研。

4　**地区自然资源系统**（Natural Resources System）

分布在各地的各种自然资源相互之间存在着有机联系，交构成一个地区性资源系统。当某一种资源被开发利用时，就会影响该系统中其他资源的生存与发展。以往对资源只是进行单项调研，其结论往往有一定的片面性，今后要以地区为单元，综合研究该地区的资源系统。这里包括着极其丰富的内容，如资源系统的结构，资源开发与生态变化的关系，资源技术经济评价的规范化，以及如何利用当地的资源系统来发展生态农业等。针对中国人均资源量低的特点，如何发展资源和能源节约型经济，值得着重研究。

5　**更认真地为农业服务**

中国是农业大国，农业生产和地理环境的关系特别密切，因此长期以来，中国地理学家始终把农业作为首要服务对象。在农业资源合理利用。作物布局、农业生产地域类型、农业区划和地区农业综合发展等方面，进行了大量工作，取得了比较有效的经验。这些工作应该继续进行下去。现在农业生产和农村经济发生了重大变化，今后为农业服务要开展一些新课题。

中国在实现社会主义市场经济过程中，要加快农业现代化建设，推动农业持续发展。为此要调整结

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构，发展多种经营方式和多种生产类型，优化产业和产品构成；增加投入，提高农业综合生产力；依靠科技，实现高产、优质、低耗、高效，提高资源产出率；防止污染，保持农业生态平衡；增加收入，走共同富裕的道路。

在近期要配合政府抓好“米袋子”、“菜篮子”，和乡镇企业三件大事而开展研究。首先要保证全国人民吃饱，在种好20亿亩耕地的同时要面向整个国土资源，科学开发非耕地资源和水域，改变传统粮食的观念，广辟食物来源，增加食物总量。调整种植业为三元（粮食、经济、饲料作物）结构，大力发展饲料作物、养殖业、饲料工业和食品工业。乡镇企业不能过于分散，可结合小城镇建设适当集中布局，防止污染；要因地制宜采取多种形式与结构内容，发挥劳动密集和传统工艺的优势，生产为大工业配套服务的产品和出口创汇的产品；把种植业、养殖业和加工业协调配合起来，促进农业产业化经营，实现产供销一体化和贸工农一体化，改变“小生产、大市场”的状况，逐步向农村规模经济方向发展。把农业与农村发展联系在一起，从而推进农业向专业化、社会化、商品化和产业化发展，逐步实现农业现代化、农村工业化、农村城镇化和城乡一体化的高层次结合。再进一步改变长期以来工农、城乡隔离的二元结构为工农协调、城乡结合发展。

6 重点区域研究

中国地理学素向有重视区域研究的伟大传统，一千多年前开始编写的地方志包含了丰富的区域地理资料。1980年在东京召开的国际地理大会号召复兴区域地理学，认为区域地理学是地理学的核心。事实上地理学家善于从自然到人文来分辨地域差异性，而且也善于判断各个地区存在的优势和影响它发展的限制因素，因此，区域研究可说是地理学家的看家本领。当然，区域地理研究不能停留于罗列和描述地理环境和人文现象，而应当运用系统论的观点把区域作为一个系统来进行动态研究，在这方面可以做很多工作。

首先从全国范围来说，1986—87年中国地理工作者曾配合国家计委国土司编写了“全国国土总体规划纲要”，可以在这个基础上进行一些后续研究。例如可以根据资源优化配置和有效利用的原则，研究如何确当布局生产力，从而促进地区经济的合理分工与协调发展，以形成有利于发挥地区优势和区域协作的经济体系。把全国经济的统一性和地区经济的特色结合起来，逐步实现全国范围内的资源合理利用和生产力优化配置，还可进行全国经济区划的研究，论证每个区的综合发展的模式。这些都是超前研究，其成果可以提供计划部门制定相应方案作为依据。

从全世界而论，南北贫富差别是一大问题，已引起各方的注意和研讨。在中国，东南半壁和西北半壁从自然条件到人口分布、生产基础、文化水平等存在着多方面的差别，可说是地区之间的基本矛盾。自改革开放以来，东、中、西三个地带之间由于政策向沿海倾斜，于是差距越来越拉大，这是亟待研究的问题，如不能妥善缓解，将形成更大的地理不稳定性（geographical instability）。

中国要面向世界，谈到重点区域研究就不能遗忘他的海疆。中国有绵长18000公里的海岸线，6000多个大小岛屿，除了法定的领海而外，还有200海里以内可能划归中国管理的将近300万平方公里的专属经济区，具体有待于和海上邻国协商划定。从各方面来看，中国无疑是个重要的海洋国家，而中国对海域的研究正好是一个薄弱环节，亟待加强。对于海域的研究还要和陆域联系起来，如黄海与东北亚的发展关系，南海和东南亚的发展关系等等。要注意国际地缘政治和地缘经济新形势和中国发展的关系。

关于重点区域研究还要抓好两头，一头是国家投入较多，准备加快发展的地区，如西藏的“一江两河”地区，沿新大陆桥东段（陇海线）、京九线、南昆线地区，由于交通运输条件改进将如何带动沿线产业布局与经济发展；另一头是生态特别脆弱的地区（如长城一线的半干旱区、西部山区等），可结合脱贫致富问题进行研究。

此外，中国人文地理界准备组织编写包括20多卷的“中国人文地理丛书”，该套丛书的出版，将比较全面地呈现90年代中国人文地理研究的新貌。

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PROSPECT ON THE DEVELOPMENT OF HUMAN GEOGRAPHY IN CHINA

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Key Words: Chinese human geography; Man-nature relationship; Sustainable development; Global change; Resource system; Regional comprehensive development

Abstract

In China, since the implementation of reform and open door policies, human geography has got rejuvenated, and much progress has been made in its theory, method and research contents. Of its branch sciences, economic geography, urban geography and geography of tourism are the most active ones, and political geography, social geography and cultural geography, which were regarded as "forbiden areas" before, have been broken through, and have produced encouraging results. Now under the influence of diverting from planned economy to market economy, human geography is facing new challenges while winning unprecedented development opportunities.

Stepping forward into the 21st century, the emphasis of human geographiccal studies, as the author suggests, should be put on the following topics:

(1) for reinforcing the basic theory of human geography, to study the area system of man -nature relationship;

(2) for coordinating with the realization of the "21st Agenda for China", to study the social and ecomic sustainable development of the country and various regions;

(3) to study the relations between human activities and global changes, taking land-use as its central item;

(4) from the point of view of saving and protecting resources, to study

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area natural resources system;

(5) carrying forward the Chinese tradition of serving agriculture, to study the way of promoting sustainable development of agriculture and rural settlements;

(6) in order to raise the level of regional geography in theory and practice and to meet the tasks asigned by governmental agencies, to study the comprehensive development of various regions, including the main developing regions, the sea territory, and the crucial zones.

The development of human geography in China during the last 50 years is not so smooth. In the 1950s, copied from the Soviet experiences, human geography was lablled as "pseudo science", and many human geographical works were critized politically. Until 1978 after the Cultural Revolution, the Chinese government shifted the gravity of national work from class struggle to economic reconstructions, scientific work was then ushered into spring time. The Geographical Society of China sponsored a national congress at the end of 1979, an important resolution was adopted to rejuvenate human geography, for not only to achieve the balance development of the Chinese geography, but also to meet the objective need of national modernization. Since then, many branches of human geography, such as political geography, social geography and cultural geography which were regarded as "forbiden areas" due to political reasons, have been broken through and reinforced, and more and more young geographers devote to the speciality of human geography.

During the last 20 years of reformation, human geography has attened rapid advancement, its research contents expanded and much diversified. Geographers actively engaged in the studies of territorial development, management and planning, agricultural regionalization and comprehensive planning for rural settlement, urban planning, urban system and evaluation of land in the urban areas, the reasonable utilization of land resources and toruist resourecs, integrated management of environment and its suitable carrying capacity, the optimate allocation of productive forces and comprehensive development of regions, and basic theoretical problems like the area system of man-nature relationship, etc. Meanwhile, National Economic Atlas, National Agricultural Atlas, and national scale atlases of land-use and population were published, and all of them were awarded with national prizes. Besides, a special collection of monographs covering all the branches of human geography were published. It shows that human geographical researches in China has entered into a new prosperous period.

As the existing problems in the process of modernization of the country are usually comprehensive in character, and in order to solve the problems it recuires scientists of different specialities to work cooperatively. Therefore, the development of geography needs sychronizing further specialization with high integration. Thus, more and more physical geog-

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raphers have joined human geographical works in China lately, altering the situation that physical geographers and human geographers don't care about each other and go by different roads as in the previours years. Meanwhile, geographers no longer encircle themselves in the geographical party but contact experts of physical, social and technical sciences to work together intercrossly. The result of such intercross studies promoted the birth of many crisscross sciences like regional science, environmental science, resource science, geo-economics, urban science, human ecology, etc. Some of them have mingled to such extent as " I within you and you within me" such as economic geography and regional science, and W. Isard vividly call them "twin sciences".

The research of human geography has evolved from tackling single element to multiple elements, from sectoral to integrated development, from static description to dynamic analysis, and from qualitative review to accurate dimension. Human geographers have paid much attention to improve their research method, so as to "harden" the soft science. By so doing, the Chinese geographers find common way, common means and common language with their foreign colleagues, so as to connect the track in international cooperation, and enable them to advance to the forefront of geographical studies.

In view of China's diversified geographical environment, long history of culture, huge population with many nationalities, and based on such national conditions, it is possible for the chinese geographers to establish a human geography with unique Chinese characteristics.

The human geographical studies must be closely based on the national conditions of China, that the process of industrialization has not yet been fundamentally realized, population pressure is high, the level of urbanization is low, the urban-rural dual structure has negative effect on many respects, the increasing surplus rural labourers has to be accommodated, the geographical environment and the level of culture, economy and technique are unbalanced among different nationalities, therefore production and reconstruction works should pay attention to not only adapting to the local conditions, but also seeking justice to the related regions and Nationalities, so as to gaurantee polical stability and mational unity of the country.

The branch of economic geography is directly affected by the change of economic system from planned economy to market economy since 1978. The Chinese economic geography devoted to the study of production only in the previous years, has now been expanded to the study of circulation, exchange and consumption as well, and the study of allocation of productive forces expanded to that of industrial sectors and economy as a whole. In order to adjust to the new situation of market economy, economic geographers have to renew their ideas and to change their knowledge structure, particularly to master the mechenics of and the behaviour under the market system. Thus they will encounter many difficulties.

The Chinese human geography is now at an important turning point, it is facing new challenges while winning unprecedented development oppertunities. While stepping into the

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21st century, in moulding the strategy of developping human geography, we have to understand the main tendencies of human geography in the developed countries, so as to try to match with them, and what is more important is to meet the needs of the economic and social development of the country. The author suggests that the emphasis of Chinese human geography should be put on the following aspects:

1. The areal (spatial) system of man—nature relationship

The topic is the core of geographical studies and also the main component of its basic theories. As geography is the linking subject between the science of knowing the physical world and that knowing the human world, the knot that joins the two sciences is man-nature relationship. Of course, besides geography there are many sciences tackling the problem of man-nature relationship, srch as social science, biological science and philosophy, but geography is the only discipline that tackles the problem on the basis of area. Contemporary geography studies the big system of the earth surface, composed of 2 sub-systems of the environment and the human society. The big system, consisting multiple elements, is rather complicated in its structure and with many levels and obvious area differtiation. The integrated study of the dynamic change of the area system of man-nature relationship at different stage of social development and the characteristics of area differrentiation is just the main peculiarity that distinguish geography from other sciences.

The aim of this kind of study is to coordinate the man-nature relationship in areas of different types, to attend dynamic balance between human activity and geographical environment and to optimize the structure of the relationship between the two within the area, so as to secure sustainable development of the area. Coordinating the area system of man-nature relationship is just the foothold upon which we can develop the basic theory of human geography.

2. Sustainable development of the country and various regions

In compliance with the "Agenda 21st" proclaimed by the Rio Conference on Environment and Development in 1992, China has very actively adopted "Agenda 21st for China" in 1995. There are so many items in the agenda related to the geographical works, however its central idea is to coordinate the realtions among population, resources and environment, so as to achieve social and economic sustainable development of the country or certain region. Geographers have vividly expressed the idea with PRED (population-resources-environment-development) model. In the guidance of the Agenda, to tackle the law of regulating man-nature relationship, and to set up the PRED model for the country and different regions, should be the main direction for attack of the Chinese human geographical studies in the near future. And based on this kind of study, a new branch of development geography could be found.

3. The relation between human activity and global change

About 10 years ago, research of global change was initiated by WMC and ICSU, clima-

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tologists and biologists took the lead in the work. And in the late 1980s, IFIAS and UNU suggested adding the human influence to the topic, and ISSC is now responsible for organizing this kind of study, but so far not much result has been published. Our intention is to take land-use as the main indicator to investigate and explore the relations between human activities and global change, as land-use is concrete and easier to be measured. This kind of study could be carred out with the development of certain marginal areas and with remoulding of the critical zones.

4. Area natural resource system

There are close organic links among the natural resources that distributed in the same area, and they constitute an area system, whenever one kind of resource is exploited it will affect the existence and development of other resources in the areal system. The conclusion reached by the study of a single resource might be one sided, so integrated study of areal natural resource system, including the structure of the system, the relation between resource exploitation and ecological change, the techno-economic appraisal of resources, and how to develop ecological agriculture based on local resources is advocated. As the per capita resource amount is not high in China, so how to save and protect natural resources, and how to establish resource-saving type of economy are needed to be studied.

5. To serve agriculture more effectively

China is a grand agricultural country, and the relation between agricultural activities and geographical environment is so close, thus the Chinese geographers take agriculture as their main object to be served since long ago, and they have done quite a lot of work in the rational utilization of agricultural resources, allocation of crops, area types of agriculture, agricultural regionalization, and planning of comprehensive development of agriculture and rural economy, etc., and they have certainly got some successful expierences in practice. Now under the socialist market system, Chinese agriculture is undergoing drastic changes, the structure of agriculture has to be adjusted from dual to triple (food crops, industrial crops and fodder), the scale of cultivation has to be enlarged, the way of management has to be improved from individual to cooperative, the input of fund, material and techniques to the land has to be increased, and the disperse distribution of rural industries in villages has to be properly concentrated in small towns and their products to meet the needs of the domestic and foreign markets, thus links farming-manufacturing-trade together and combining production-supply-saling hand in hand, the modernization of agriculture is promoted. Agro-geographers are now interested in the relations between sustainable development of agriculture and the urbanization of rural settlements, and the way of enhancing the link between the rural and the urban.

6. The integrated development of regions of different types

Regional study is one of the grand traditions of Chinese geography. About 1000 years ago, the compiling of Fang Zhi (local gazetteer), which contains plentiful geographical in-

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formation, has begun in China. Geographers are experts at distinguishing area differentiation and judging the superiority and limiting factors of various regions, so that regional study may be regarded as their special skill. Many geographers take that regional geography is the core of geographical science, and it should not be ignored any longer, of course the theory and practice of regional geography will give to be renewed, not just descriptive narration but to take regions a system and to find out the way of realizing its sustainable development.

In this respect, many researches could be carried out.

Firstly to take China as a big system, in 1986-87 economic geographers joined the State Planning Commission in drafting the "Outline of National Territorial Planning", and on this basis many succeeding works need to be done. For example, through properly allocating productive forces, reasonable division of labour among different regions could be planned, so as to establish regional cooperation system of the country. Besides, economic regionalization is also an important topic to be studied.

Regional disparities, like the South-North problem of the world, is cuite a problem in China as well. The basic disparity exists between the 2 halves of China, the SE and the NW, the former is the developed and the latter is yet undeveloped. Since the implementation of the open door policy, China's coastal regions developed so quickly that the interior lagged far behind, and the increasing differentiation has to be mitigated otherwise geographical instability might happen.

China is a continental-marine nation, while facing th outside world, the study of her sea territory could not be neglected. China has a long shoreline of 18000 km, about 6000 islands and islets scattered in the nearby seas, and besides her territorial sea within 12 knots along the coast and there may be, according to the International Sea Pact, about 3 million square km of exclusive economic zone which will have yet to be finally divided through negotiations with her 8 neighboring countries on the sea. The study of seas is to be linked with the related lands, such as the Yellow Sea with NE Asia, the South China Sea with the SE Asia, and taking into consideration of the intrenational geo-political and geo-economic situations.

The emphasis of regional studies will also be put on those regions that are planned to be given priority in development, such as the zone along the newly built Beijing-Kowlon railway and that along the Kunming-Nanning railway, and the "1 jiang 2 he" area of Central Tibet. And on the other hand, critical zones like the semi-arid zone outside the Great Wall and the mountainous areas in SW China, are to be surveyed under the "take off poverty and bring about richness" program sponsored by the Chinese government.

In addition, a series of monographs of "Chinese Human Geography", more than 20 volumes, are to be published before 2000, which, under the author's chief editorialship, will show the full picture of the development of the science in China.

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